UX Research Insights.

Project: **Ray | Comparison feature concept testing**
Context: Concept test to understand how users evaluate and choose buses, and how they perceive and use the proposed bus comparison feature.
Interviewed cohort: 6 units (New/ returning rB users, Tier1/3)

User Recordings , Prototype link , Discussion Guide

General observations before exposing the prototype:

1) Decision making is not based on price or ratings first. **Operator familiarity, time, and seat availability matter more than small price differences.** *Ratings are only a pass/fail check, with binary threshold at 4.0 (pass/fail)*

2) Reasons to click a bus option to learn more before choosing *(anecdotal observation based on only 6 users, can't take the splits literally for mass audience)*
   - Priority 1: Seat availability, seat location, and seat price.
   - Priority 2: Amenities, photos, and reviews.
   - Priority 3: Cancellation policy, boarding points (direct or van), and boarding time.

3) Two behaviours emerge:
   - **Need help choosing (New RB user/ New Route user/ Offline to Online user)**: Users who don't know which option to choose or lack knowledge about operators, route stops, or which filters to apply and need assistance with picking.
   - **Looking for added value (Techsavy / HF RB user)**: Users who already know what they want and have found an option, but want a recommendation to see if there's a better alternative that offers extra value.

4) Trade offs observed when choosing a bus: *(anecdotal observation based on only 6 users, can't take the splits literally for mass audience)*
   - **Time & seat location over price** : Users are willing to pay extra or choose a lower rated bus to reach their destination at a specific time or get their preferred seat location.
   - **Seat location over travel time**: Users accept a slightly longer journey if they can get their preferred seat location.

- **Time over comfort score**: Users accept lower comfort ratings if the bus timing is better.(comfort score of more than 8 is seen as same and less than 8 is seen as same, 8 is the differentiator to consider or not consider.)

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Caveat:

- Users' hesitation to rely on Ray stems from **limited familiarity** rather than negative experience; clearer prompts could better communicate its capabilities, practical benefits, reliability, or potential time savings and encourage exploration.*(e.g., "Compare these buses further" or "Change date")*

- The comparison feature helps users who rely on scrolling rather than proactively applying filters by **surfacing relevant options and filters they might otherwise miss.**

- **Side by side comparison works well**, and users understand "Your Usuals" as reflecting their past searches and filters, while other highlights help surface attributes that other users commonly prioritize.

- Amenities like charging point, wifi and rest stop count/location, dinner break availability, helps in seeing value for long journeys over price or ratings

A) Popup and comparison feature

1) Popup **triggers after clicking two bus options are considered early** for **new routes /new users**: users dismiss the popup because they haven't explored enough options to establish benchmarks for price, traveller types, or boarding points. *(Especially first time popup for the user)*

2) When recommendations are based on a **mistakenly opened bus**, users abandon the feature and prefer manual search over the *effort of changing the bus for comparison*

3) Users instinctively dismiss the popup as an advertisement or distraction, often without reading it, especially **when focused on existing information** on SRP.

4) **Familiar/high-frequency users** see value in recommendations but currently prefer searching directly, making them **value recommendation over**

comparison. The AI powered recommendation gets overshadowed by the generic “Want to compare?” prompt and viewed bus tuples, causing users to perceive limited value and dismiss the popup.

5) Users who want to see the recommendation are unclear to click on “Ray recommendation” tuple or “Compare bus” to view the recommendation directly. *(We assume all users want to compare and not directly look for recommendations)*

B) Comparison page

1) The comparison feature doesn’t fully leverage users’ applied filters and preferences to optimize bus comparisons.
    - **Repeating bus details** already visible on the tuple (Bus type : Ac/Sleeper) in “Your Usuals” adds no new value and creates unnecessary clutter.
    - RAY recommendation fails when users who sort by price are shown costlier recommendations offering similar to better timings and comfort.

2) Users **need help with shortlisting or reject options seamlessly** as they struggle to distinguish direct bus boarding from van pickups and BP/DP timings for the preferred points on compare cards, unfamiliarity with Ray at this point forces users to manually reopen buses to verify details and compare among options *(Showing only “This bus stops at Hebbal” without its arrival time makes it difficult to compare buses that reach the same boarding point at different times.)*

3) The lack of journey duration, rest stop details, amenities and bus visuals forces users to manually inspect buses to identify meaningful differences and make informed choices.

4) Users can add up to 10 buses to compare, but without guidance on which buses to select, No limit cap or guidance leads to comparison fatigue *(researchers observation)*

5) Ray's recommendation :

    - Dynamically adapt recommendations for group bookings by carrying forward, if **multi seat selected from the seat layout** before recommendations, makes suggestions more relevant to the user's

actual booking needs. *(Currently assumes it is for a single booking, "Your Usuals : lower single seats available)*

- Users **prioritize trusted operators and past experiences over price, rating or AI recommendations**, recommendations fail if the operator is unfamiliar or has bad past experiences *(use users historical data where operator cancelation/ delayed pickup/ less rating in the past)*

- Despite offering better value options, Ray's recommendations are not noticed without nudging as its **buried below the fold and lack a clear visual highlight** (2/6 users)

6) Ray's Chat : Users default to manually checking drop off points, comparing prices across dates, changing dates, and removing buses because they don't realize Ray can perform these actions unless prompted.

7) The **"View Seats" dropdown lacks visual prominence**. Since users typically click on bus tuples and visit the seat layout to check seat availability, pricing, and placement, they often overlook the dropdown and click "Choose Buses" to view seats instead.

8) Users want to **remove buses instantly** by a cancel button (x) from the comparison screen rather than navigate elsewhere to remove it or type a prompt for a simple action.(2/6 users)

9) Users can't identify which buses they've already viewed or searched on the comparison screen; adding clear "Viewed" or "Searched" labels or checkmarks would improve recognition and context. (1/6 users, new user, Tier 3)

10) Users lack clear guidance on which buses to add to the comparison, making it difficult to identify the most relevant options to compare. *(researchers observation)*